



Examination Report

English Language

6873

EGCSE

2025

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PAPER 6873/01
Reading and Directed Writing

General comments

In 2025, candidates registered for the examination were 21555, a noticeable increase compared to 2024 where there were 18872. Overall, the paper proved to be a little more challenging for candidates compared to last year's paper. 2025 recorded a top score of 43 out of 50 and a lowest score of 01 out of 50.

Comments on specific questions

Exercise 1

Generally, most candidates performed well on this exercise, with exercise 1(i) being particularly accessible and allowing a high number of candidates to earn marks.

(a) What difference is there between cats and other pets?

Expected response: Cats are known to be happier on their own.

Comment

Generally, most candidates got this one correct, except for a few who misunderstood the key word, 'pets', in the question and compared cats to dogs while others failed to use the comparative, 'happier', to respond accurately to the question but used, 'happy', rendering their responses incorrect.

(b) What does the writer think is most frustrating for cats?

Expected response: a change in their environment and territory

Comment

This question was accessible to most candidates, save for those who failed to give both parts of the response or those who wrote, 'territorial', instead of 'territory'. Others failed to score because they wrote, 'or', instead of, 'and'.

(c) How can you help a cat cope with the absence of a family member?

Expected response: just leave it alone

Comment

This question was generally well-answered, except for a few candidates who did not directly respond to what one can do to help the cat but wrote, 'it needs to readjust to its territory', instead of, 'let it readjust to its territory', which was an option to the correct answer.

(d) What trait does a cat display by sitting on one's lap?

Expected response: comfort-seeking/comfort-seeker

Comment

The question was not accessible to most candidates because they failed to give a trait in their responses instead, they gave responses such as, 'comfort', or 'comfortability' which were not traits.

(e) Explain the following words as used in the passage:

(i) 'self-sufficient' (paragraph 2)

Expected response: independent/self-reliant/able to look after itself/able to survive on its own/any other appropriate word or phrase

Comment

This question proved to be difficult for most candidates as most of them failed to explain the expression using suitable synonyms or the meaning of the expression in the context it was used. They gave wrong responses such as, 'happy alone', 'care only for themselves. They equated 'self-sufficiency' with being a loner or introvert'.

(ii) 'enforce' (paragraph 2)

Expected response: teach/strengthen/encourage/instil/promote/train/cultivate/any other appropriate word or phrase

Comment

The question proved to be inaccessible to most candidates as most of them misinterpreted 'enforce', for 'force' thus distorting the meaning of the word and responding inaccurately.

(f) Compare fancy cats to feral cats.

Expected response: fancy cats are far more companionable while feral cats are more likely to have wilder cat characteristics.

Comment

The question was not accessible to most candidates, and a few got full marks. Most candidates failed to compare the two types of cats as they omitted the key word 'companionable' which is used in the text to differentiate fancy cats from feral cats. Most candidates' responses highlighted 'wilder cat characteristics' for feral cats while a few candidates who were careless wrote, 'wider', instead of 'wilder'. A good number of candidates also lifted information indiscriminately from the text and gave the following response: 'fancy cats have a certain amount of wild cat, making them far more companionable', omitting 'bred out'. This response became wrong because it then meant that fancy cats are more companionable because they have a certain amount of wild cat in them.

(g) What is the benefit of training your cat to be handled?

Expected response: it will get integrated with the family properly/it will be more pleasant around the house/it will never feel unpleasant around the house

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates. The few who did not score omitted, 'properly' in the first option which was important for the response to be correct.

(h) How can a cat owner enhance the cat's hunting behaviour?

Expected response: by using interactive hunting toys

Comment

The question was inaccessible especially to weak candidates as they failed to understand the demands of the question and identify the relevant information from the text to respond relevantly to the 'How', in the question. The common response for those who did not score was, 'by making their mealtime a game', thus failing to respond to how the mealtime is made into a game.

(i) Give four pieces of advice from the passage to help new cat owners make sure their home is a suitable environment for a cat.

Expected responses:

1. know which breed best suits your home/do your homework on the breed
2. need a covered litter box/litter box should be placed in low activity areas
3. cats need open space (to explore freely)

4. need elevated spaces (for comfort and safety)
5. need a sturdy scratching post (any four)

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates except for a few who did not seem to have understood the question and lifted information indiscriminately from the text. Others lost marks on this one because of carelessness. For instance, instead of, 'litter box', they wrote, 'little box' and instead of 'sturdy', they wrote, 'study'.

Exercise 2

This question proved to be accessible to most candidates, except for the part on conditions for gardening where candidates were scoring as little as zero out of the 3 marks.

Expected responses

Advantages of growing your own food

1. to be aware of what you are putting in your body
2. to indulge in a pleasurable task (that gets you outside)
3. improves environment

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates, save for those who lost marks because they wrote all three points on the first line and responded with wrong information for the second and third responses. A few candidates also scored zero for the first point because of carelessness as they changed, 'be aware' to 'beware', distorting the meaning of the response rendering it incorrect.

Conditions of gardening

4. healthy/well-nourished/well composted/properly mulched soil/thick carpet of mulch
5. planting when rains are around/irrigation/watering
6. full sunlight
7. gentle slope (any 3)

Comment

This question proved to be difficult for most candidates as they gave the options for the first point as responses for the second and third points. Some got a zero for not qualifying the first point with the word, 'soil'. For example, they wrote, 'well-nourished', instead of, 'well-nourished soil'. Others lifted, 'on more than a gentle slope', for point number 7 omitting, 'no', which rendered the response incorrect.

How to water plants

8. to the root zone (about 25-30 cm down)
9. drip irrigation
10. sprinkler

Comment

Most candidates were able to access this question, except for those who were careless and wrote the wrong spelling of, 'drip', writing, 'drig' or those who picked the information as it was from the text, 'a sprinkler uses more water as compared to drip irrigation', which did not directly respond to the question.

Exercise 3

Generally, this exercise was accessible to most candidates who scored above 6 out of 8, with most candidates scoring the total while there were still a few who got as little as 1 or zero out of 8.

Expected responses

- (a) B
- (b) A
- (c) D
- (d) B
- (e) C
- (f) A
- (g) D
- (h) C

Comment

Even though this exercise was generally well done and accessible to most candidates, it was discriminatory. Candidates needed to understand complex vocabulary to be able to identify the correct responses and this means high achievers in the language had the advantage of scoring full marks while weak candidates scored below 4 marks out of 8. For instance, candidates had to know the meaning of, 'multi-faceted', to be able to score in (b).

Exercise 4

Generally, this question was inaccessible to most candidates and there are still candidates who seemed to have a phobia for this question as they did not attempt it at all.

(a) What are the contrasting issues that the writer is angry about?

Expected response

Widespread poverty alongside excessive wealth and waste

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates, except to those who did not understand the word, 'contrasting' such that instead of presenting the contrast. Some candidates lost marks because of carelessness; 'widespread', became, 'wild spread', while others omitted, 'waste' in the second issue.

(b) Give a phrase from the passage that shows that history is repeating itself.

Expected response

'patterns of the past recurring'/'dangerous patterns of the past recurring'/'the past recurring'

Comment

While it is commendable that most candidates were able to identify the phrase from the text, there were still challenges as candidates failed to punctuate it properly by putting it inside quotation marks. Some also started the phrase with a capital letter. A few candidates did not spell the word, 'recurring', correctly while others picked full sentences. Therefore, the question was not accessible to most candidates.

(c) Explain the following expressions:

(i) 'A driven sense of duty to right wrongs' (paragraph 3)

Expected response

A strong responsibility/urge to correct (previous) mistakes/injustices/any other appropriate meaning.

Comment

The question was very challenging to most candidates and few candidates managed to score the full mark because even those who scored something could only score 1 out of 2 for being able to give the meaning of; 'right wrongs' which was, 'correct mistakes', in the context, while most candidates scored a zero out of 2. Most candidates had a Challenge with coming up with the meaning of the key words, 'driven sense of duty', and 'right wrongs'.

Common wrong response: a job to correct wrong things/bad things

(ii) 'War was vile, and poverty was grinding' (paragraph 4)

Expected response

'War was bad/unpleasant and poverty was extreme/any other appropriate meaning.

Comment

This question also proved to be difficult for most candidates. A few managed to get full marks, while most got either 1 mark out of 2 or zero out of 2. Candidates failed to find the meaning of the expression

in the context and they found it difficult to come up with the appropriate synonyms of the key words, 'vile' and, 'grinding'.

(d) What was the ceremony at Windsor Castle for?

Expected response

Ceremony where damehood titles are awarded/offered

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates, save for those who did not seem to understand the word, 'damehood', maybe because it was a foreign concept for them such that even after finding the answer, they said the damehood title was being offered to Queen Elizabeth, Prince William or frightened children, which rendered the response incorrect.

(e) How does the writer lift herself up when she feels down? Give two details.

Expected responses

- (i) She reminds herself that many young people are avid for change.

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates but most of them failed to score because of carelessness. They confused pronouns and instead of using the third person pronouns; 'she' and 'herself', they used, 'he', 'himself' and, 'myself'. They changed, 'avid' to 'vivid' and omitted, 'young', which was important for the response to score. Some changed 'young' to 'black'.

- (ii) Watches the dawn from her bedroom window (and enjoys the sun).

Comment

The question was accessible to most candidates, but again a majority of them did not score because of carelessness. They omitted, 'bedroom window' which was important for the response to score. Some wrote the wrong spelling of, 'dawn' and wrote, 'down'. They also failed to use the correct person's point of view or correct pronouns as they used 'he' for 'she' and used the incorrect pronoun, 'my', instead of, 'her.'

Exercise 5

Write a summary of the disadvantages of fashion and how consumers can stop this phenomenon.

Expected responses

Disadvantages of fashion

1. Advancing problems of child labour and human trafficking
2. Factory plants that are unethical in the creation of their products/global clothing brands require large numbers of items that are produced unethically in factories
3. Lives and health of the workers affected in factory plants supplying retailers
4. Women and young workers are trapped into poverty
5. Polluting/contaminating rivers
6. Pollution resulting in cancer and birth deformities
7. Dyes (containing toxic chemicals/nonylphenol) linked to allergic eye and skin reactions (any 3)

How consumers can stop this phenomenon

8. Support initiatives that work to eradicate fast fashion
9. Focus on quality not quantity/curate your closet/stop spending finances on items you will not use anyway and choose clothing that will benefit you for longer
10. Demand transparency from your favourite retailers
11. Support retailers that take their social responsibility seriously (any 3)

Comment

The question proved to be difficult to a majority of candidates because a few candidates were able to identify 5 or 6 points in response to the question. Most candidates were able to identify 4 or less than 4 points out of 6, with some not even getting 1 point, scoring a zero out of 10. Notably, most candidates failed to select relevant information and lifted irrelevant points, thus exceeding the stipulated length, writing points that did not respond to the given question. Most candidates were getting the three points responding to the first part of the question because they only identified the disadvantages of fashion, discussing 4 or more of the disadvantages and running short of space for the, 'how part'. Others exceeded the stipulated length before they could answer the given question because they copied paragraph one word for word which was not responding to the summary question. There were still those who wrote unnecessary introductions and those who wrote the summary in more than one paragraph. Most candidates lost marks for using wrong synonyms of words when they were trying to use their own words. For example, they used, 'children', to substitute, 'young workers', in point number 4. This cohort also had careless candidates who wrote wrong spellings of words and omitted key words even after identifying the correct points.

Recommendations

It is recommended that:

1. Learners are trained on question analysis and made to understand that in most cases the questions use synonyms of the words used in the texts which lead them to the correct responses.
2. Teachers continue doing a lot of reading and text analysis in class with learners on different subjects and texts.
3. Learners are trained to understand the writer's intended meaning, writer's attitude and how to find meanings of words and expressions in the context in which they are used.
4. Learners are taught the difference between a sentence, clause or phrase, and to use appropriate punctuation marks if they are asked to pick a phrase, clause or sentence from a given text.
5. Learners are taught to use appropriate words like, 'yet', 'while', etc., when asked to compare things and bring out both sides of the things being compared to score full marks.
6. Learners are trained to differentiate between main ideas and other information meant to develop those main ideas, like examples in order to do well in note making and summary writing.
7. Teachers emphasise on the use of the correct person's point of view when answering questions. For example, instead of using the first person used in the text, they should use the third person.

PAPER 6873/02
Continuous Writing

The paper consists of three exercises: Exercise 1, Exercise 2 and Exercise 3.

Exercise 1 and Exercise 2 are compulsory, then for Exercise 3 candidates choose one question out of three. In fact, the questions consist of: Exercise 1 and 2 which are guided writing tasks and Exercise 3 is free/creative writing.

The total mark in this paper is **50**. The highest score obtained this year (2025) was **48/50** which is an improvement from the year 2024 which had the highest score of **45/50**. **129** candidates scored **40 and above**. The lowest score was **0/50** which is similar to the 2024 lowest score.

Notably, this year there were 60 candidates who scored from 0 to 10 among which 14 scored 0 in all three exercises.

The paper was accessible. However, the candidates were challenged by the questions due to weak question analysis and lack of appropriate language.

Comments on specific questions

Exercise 1: Informal Letter Writing

Question

You and your friends attended a motivational talk, where you were taught about having a high self-esteem, which you found to be educational and interesting.

Write a letter to your cousin sharing your experience.

In your letter include the following:

- where you attended the talk and with whom
- what fascinated you about the talk
- how you will implement what you have learnt.

Your letter should be 1 page (**about 150-200 words**) long.

You will receive up to 7 marks for content for your letter and up to 7 marks for style and accuracy of your language.

Expectations

The task was a friendly/informal letter.

The purpose was that the candidate shares their experience on a motivational talk they attended where they were taught about having a high self-esteem, which they found educational and interesting.

The audience was a cousin; thus the register is **informal/chatty**.

The tone is friendly (casual).

The Format / structure

Introduction

- ✓ portray social distance: casual opening, friendly tone, pleasantries e.g. asking about the cousin's well-being
- ✓ the purpose i.e. the reason they are writing the letter may be highlighted here. (Examiners should, however, note that it may not be overt and may not be included here at all)

Body

- ✓ development of bullets or ideas to show or demonstrate independence of thought

The key phrase or words **your experiences on a motivational talk about having a high self-esteem which you attended** lead to the expectation of specific ideas and not general ideas. The candidate is expected to write something personal. In other words, they should relate ideas to themselves.

- ✓ **The candidates were expected to develop all given ideas(bullets):**
 - Where you attended the talk and with whom – the place where this talk was, the candidate may further illustrate how this location was special to them and add the person they attended with. They may add place, time, date, attendees, facilitator etc.
 - What fascinated you – in this bullet the candidate must show what interested them. They may highlight mode of delivery and what was most interesting and informative to them. They may highlight what they did not know and might have learnt from this talk in relation to self-esteem and other relevant ideas.
 - How you will implement what you learnt – the candidate is expected to explain how they will use what they gained from the talk in aspects of their lives. Ideas may include behaviour change, focus, priorities etc. The candidate may share how they will incorporate what they learnt in their lives, it may be in their daily experiences or even in their educational endeavours.

Conclusion

- ✓ The conclusion is supposed to reconnect to the purpose of the letter.

Ending: e.g. Your loving cousin Sibusisiwe

The candidate was expected to use the appropriate register, show creativity, independence of thought in developing the ideas and use appropriate and sophisticated language.

Moreover, the candidate was expected to adhere to grammatical conventions, and the letter was supposed to be 150-200 words or a page long of standard handwriting.

Overall performance

This question was not accessible to most candidates as they were not able to give good responses. Most candidates did not meet the demand of the question, and they were not able to develop the given bullets adequately. Some bullets were not even attempted such as the bullet on what fascinated them about the motivational talk and how to implement what they learnt from the talk. Many candidates instead of implementation discussed lessons learnt. Others did not have an idea of what self-esteem is and what it involves. They went on to bring in youth development programmes, farming, and business-related ideas. It appears as if they forgot about the given scenario and created their own scenarios which were not relevant to the given topic.

Some candidates seemed to lack exposure, resulting in weak responses. The other problem was their command of the language which was weak as most of them used lame expressions.

Good responses

A good response for Exercise 1 was one that demonstrated awareness of purpose, audience and register as well as those that addressed all the bullet points adequately. Good responses were from candidates who:

- wrote an informal letter;
- fully developed all prompts and displayed independence of thought;
- used a chatty tone or informal register;
- used contractions appropriately;
- used words or vocabulary that related to self-esteem;
- used the relevant diction for sharing an exciting and interesting experience;

Weak responses

Candidates who wrote weak responses were those who:

- did not show awareness of audience, hence they used a formal tone;
- did not address all the bullets but focused on only one or two leaving out the second and third bullet;
- listed and did not develop the bullets;
- did not analyse the question thus they created their own questions;
- used language which showed lack of awareness of mechanical awareness/accuracy;
- did not paragraph their work and some paragraphs had no punctuation at all resulting in many runs on sentences
- no understanding of the key words 'self-esteem', 'fascinated' and 'implement'

- exposure to motivational talks could not assist candidates to respond well to the question as they wrote about motivation that was not in line with the question e.g. some wrote about youth empowerment or business related talk.
- concluded with the last bullet instead of developing it;
- could not distinguish between slang and informal language and used slang words like *wanna*, *kinda* and *gonna*;
- used formal language and cohesive devices like firstly, secondly, moreover, furthermore, hence, and so on;
- used social media language e.g. *az*, *coz*, *u*;
- wrote lengthy introductions which led to mediocre responses as candidates failed to develop all the bullets adequately;
- wrote their own letters which were not relevant to the task as they created their own questions.

Exercise 2: Formal Writing

Question

Your school is in the process of electing prefects for the current year, and you are convinced that you are the suitable candidate for the Head Prefect position. The school has presented you with an opportunity to campaign during morning assembly.

Write a speech to present on the day.

In your speech you must include:

- who you are and your current position in the school
- qualities that make you ideal for the head prefect position
- changes you will bring about in the school.

Your letter should be 1 page (**about 150-200 words**) long.

You will receive up to 7 marks for the content for your speech and up to 7 marks for style and accuracy of your language.

Expectations

The task was **to write a speech (persuasive speech)**.

The purpose was to **'persuade the school to elect you as the head prefect for your school'**.

The candidates were expected to develop the bullets or points, and 'sell' themselves into being elected as the head prefect of their school.

The candidate was expected to use appropriate persuasive language and techniques to drive their point home.

The Format /structure

Introduction

- ✓ The candidate was expected to observe protocol, introduce themselves, give greetings and further give the purpose of their speech.

Body

The candidate was expected to be persuasive and develop the following bullets.

- Who you are and your current position in the school – your name, class, current position e.g. Deputy Head Prefect, class prefect/monitor etc. The candidate may also make mention of previous leadership positions they may have occupied prior to the current one.
- Qualities that make you ideal for the head prefect position – (the candidate must outline specific qualities that make them a suitable head prefect. Here they must maintain the persuasive tone, and further stress why they see themselves as better leaders than others who might also be campaigning.)
- Changes you will bring about in the school – Candidate may talk about things they will improve for the well-being of the learners, how to improve the learners' welfare (the candidate may display awareness of the challenges faced by the students and prove to have solutions to solve these issues. The candidate should continue to be persuasive and portray themselves as some sort of 'saviour'.

The candidate was expected to show creativity, independence of thought in developing the ideas and use appropriate and sophisticated language.

Conclusion

There are many ways in which candidates could conclude their speech in relation to the purpose.

The speech was expected to be paragraphed appropriately.

Overall performance

This question was accessible to most candidates, yet most candidates' responses were average. A majority of the candidates knew the expectations of a speech though they failed to persuade, market or sell themselves. Some failed to understand the purpose maybe because of failure to analyse the question, which resulted in some responses demonstrating that they were giving speech showing that already they were elected as the Head Prefect instead of requesting to be elected. There were some candidates who wrote argumentative articles showing insufficient awareness of purpose.

Good responses

Candidates who gave good responses are those who:

- displayed an understanding of the task.
- were able to advocate for their election.

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- presented well developed ideas clearly using a persuasive style and developed all the given prompts adequately.
- displayed independence of thought.
- used good language and appropriate persuasive techniques or marketing strategies.
- used **relevant** novel or fresh ideas

Weak responses

Candidates who gave weak responses:

- did not understand that the task was a persuasive piece of writing;
- wrote articles instead of speeches
- wrote speeches that showed lack of awareness of the purpose and register since some had already been elected into the position.
- did not develop some bullets, especially the bullet on current position and the one on changes resulting in shopping list style of presentation of points.
- did not differentiate between the roles of the head teacher and head prefect, especially when addressing the prompt on changes.
- did not persuade for position but instead threatened the audience.
- no independence of thought;
- used language that depicted lack of mechanical accuracy: wrong punctuation, rambling or sentence fragments;
- discussed throughout the speech.

Exercise 3

Write about 350-450 words on ONE of the following:

1. Write an **essay** on **how** to revive the economy in your country.
2. Social media has saved the world. **Discuss**
3. Write a **story** based on the words "...that taught me a lesson of a lifetime..."

QUESTION 1: Expository writing

Write an essay on how to revive the economy in your country.

- ✓ The candidate was expected to outline ways/methods that will revive the economy of their country.
- ✓ Writing an informative essay, the candidate could identify the economic challenges their country is facing then suggest solutions that will revive or resuscitate the economy.
- ✓ The candidate was expected to show independence of thought and give developed paragraphs.
- ✓ Better responses would be able to support their suggested solutions and further cement with evidence by giving examples and show creativity.

The Format /structure

Introduction

- ✓ The candidate was expected to give background information/status quo of the economy or define a key term.
- ✓ The candidate was expected to clearly state the purpose of the essay, which is to state ways or strategies on how the economy can be revived in the country.

Body

- ✓ The candidate was expected to be informative and expand their ideas giving solutions on how to revive the economy in their country.
- ✓ They were expected to follow the rules of paragraph development and give solid paragraphs.
- ✓ The task was expected to be developed at appropriate length.
- ✓ The candidate was expected to show mechanical accuracy.

Conclusion

- ✓ The candidate was expected to emphasise the purpose of the essay: the ideal state of a stable economy.

Overall performance

This question was not popular. The few who attempted it performed exceptionally well.

Good responses

Candidates who gave good responses are those who:

- wrote an expository essay which captured the expectations of the task, that, is to explain **how** to revive the economy in your country;
- used the appropriate language and vocabulary to express their points or ideas;
- material was excellently developed using correct grammar and appropriate diction.
- addressed the issue at hand effectively.
- produced well organised and informative pieces of writing.
- they really educated the reader.
- showed independence of thought.
- essays had cohesion and coherence making them interesting to read.

Weak responses

Candidates who gave weak responses are those who:

- failed to develop ideas giving a list of points which were not related to question;

- failed to give valid points as to how the economy should be revived;
- failed to understand the status quo of the country hence they could not identify the challenges in order to bring the solutions;
- presented material that was not adequately developed.

Question 2: Discursive piece of writing

Social media has saved the world. Discuss.

The instruction or command word is '**discuss**'.

The candidate was expected **to discuss the given statement, 'social media has saved the world'**. They were expected **to explore both angles/sides of the issue, i.e. social media has or has not saved the world.**

The Format /structure

Introduction

- ✓ The candidate could give background information/status quo.
- ✓ The candidate could give a definition of 'Social media'.
- ✓ The candidate was not expected to take a stand or lean on a certain angle.

Body

There are different styles of handling or tackling the task at hand:

- ✓ The candidate may focus on the first angle in the first half of the essay and then move on to the other angle.
- ✓ The candidate may focus on one angle in one paragraph and then another angle in the following paragraph and do same in subsequent paragraphs.
- ✓ The candidate may deal with both angles in the same paragraph.

Conclusion

Candidate **may** take a stand in the conclusion.

Overall performance

This was the most popular question out of the three in this exercise. Generally, it was the most accessible question. Most candidates were familiar with the topic, resulting in most of them understanding the task at hand.

Good responses

Candidates who gave good responses are those who:

- wrote a discursive essay which captured the expectations of the task, that is, discuss whether social media has saved the world or not;
- used relevant approaches to the topic thus producing excellent discussions

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- used appropriate cohesive devices to produce a balanced discussion;
- material was excellently developed using correct grammar;
- addressed both sides of the discussion.

Weak responses

Candidates who gave weak responses are those who:

- failed to write a balanced discussion, only presenting a one sided essay failing to bring about the desired effect on how it has saved or not saved the world;
- deviated from discussing on how social media has saved or not saved the world and wrote about the internet, technology, television and media;
- wrote argumentative essays;
- changed the question and decided to write on advantages and disadvantages of social media, thus achieving partial success to the expected task;
- failed to analyse the question making them not able to respond to the 'how' part;
- used inappropriate language;
- presented material that was not adequately developed.

Question 3: Narrative piece of writing

Write a story based on the words "...that taught me a lesson of a lifetime..."

The candidate is expected to write an interesting story. The story should emanate from the given words. There should be an element of introspection in the story as depicted by the given words. As the story unfolds, there should be details about how that experience has given the writer a lesson of a lifetime. There should be a clear plot, suspense and great use of language (use narrative techniques). The element of learning the lesson should come out prominently.

The narrative was expected to give detailed information on the prelude to the lesson being learnt ... the plot builds up to the lesson (link the lesson to the story narrated)

The Format / Structure

- ✓ Introduction
- ✓ Body
- ✓ Conclusion

The candidate was expected to show creativity, independence of thought in developing the ideas and use appropriate and sophisticated language. Better responses would show mastery of the chosen narrative technique.

Overall performance

This question was not attempted by a lot candidates. There were many captivating responses demonstrating an ability at narrative writing, though there were stories which failed to meet the expectations of the question.

Good responses

Candidates who gave good response are those who:

- wrote a narrative essay (good responses took the descriptive narrative approach);
- captured the theme of the story and wrote realistic stories on an incident that taught them a lifetime lesson;
- included all the elements of a story: characters, setting and a clear plot;
- used appropriate language (including strong words, figurative language, adjectives and adverbs);
- material was excellently developed;
- observed mechanical accuracy.

Weak responses

Candidates who gave weak responses:

failed to understand that the lesson stems from a negative experience;

- lacked narrative techniques which made the story line uninteresting;
- did not capture the theme of the story;
- wrote a story that was a twist of what they were expected to write, for example, someone else learned the lesson. However, there were very few candidates who did that effectively using the appropriate language, they told the story as if they were listening to someone else narrating on their experience and that person learnt the lesson of a lifetime e.g. in direct speech;
- lacked creativity, stories were flat and lacked suspense;
- attempted all three questions in their story;
- paragraphs were absent and those present were made of run on sentences;
- changed point of view from first person singular narration to third person singular narration;
- translated siSwati sayings to English.
- Notably, some candidates used explicit language which is unpalatable.

Recommendations

It is recommended that:

- Candidates are encouraged to read extensively in order to expose themselves to a variety of writing strategies.

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- Candidates be exposed to different persuasive texts, for example: speech, article, letter, advertisement and so on.
 - Candidates are exposed to the learning of grammar in context so that they are exposed to the appropriate language used in a variety of contexts.
 - Candidates are taught question analysis skills.
 - Mechanical accuracy is encouraged: proper use of dialogue, direct speech spelling, and punctuation.
 - Candidates are capacitated on the elements, developments and techniques of writing a story.
 - Writing using a pencil and then overwriting with pen is discouraged.
 - Candidates are trained on paragraph development.
 - Candidates are taught and trained on persuasive styles that work to their advantage.
-
- Candidates are exposed to appropriate reading materials.
 - Candidates are warned against the use of explicit language.
 - Candidates must be taught about boundaries in writing and desist from using profane or vulgar language.

PAPER 6873/03 Listening Comprehension
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General Comments

The 2025 paper proved to be challenging for a significant number of candidates compared to that of the previous year. Exercises that were fairly accessible to the candidates were Exercise 1, 2 and 3 while Exercise 4 and 5 proved to be somewhat inaccessible for most candidates. As a result, no candidate attained total marks in the component. The highest was 28 but it is worth mentioning that there were a few candidates who were able to score within the 20-to-28-mark range. It is worth mentioning that the last two exercises contributed to the overall difficulty of the paper.

Candidates performed well on straightforward comprehension and recall tasks but struggled with technical vocabulary, extended reasoning and topic-specific knowledge (especially regarding the International Space Station). Spelling and grammatical accuracy were significant barriers to clarity. Successful answers were those that were precise, well-structured and used appropriate terminology. Training in exam technique, topic familiarity and foundational literacy would likely improve performance.

Exercise 1

General Comment

This exercise was accessible to a majority of the candidates.

Question 1

State any two items that Mike should bring for the weekend.

Expected response: red T shirt, jeans, dancing shoes.

Comment

A majority of candidates were able to score a mark. However, some candidates could not score due to spelling mistakes such as; red ti shirt, red t- shert, tea shirt, te shirt.

Question 2

What is the venue for the workshop?

Expected response: Gallery Hotel (in Matsapha)

Comment

The question was accessible to a majority the of candidates. However, some candidates came up with new words such as Motel and Hostel.

Question 3

Why do flamingos stand on one leg?

Expected response: to save energy

Comment

The question was accessible to a majority of candidates. Some candidates wrote new words which distorted the meaning, for example, serve. Wrong spellings included enegy.

Question 4

What is parosmia?

Expected response: Experiencing distortion of the sense of smell.

Comment

The question was accessible to a majority of candidates but some could not score as a result of spelling mistakes and omission of key words. For example; distoshin, distontion.

Question 5

State one feature that the building has.

Expected response: roof made of solar spines / massive steel wings/ pier

Comment

The question was accessible to a majority of candidates. Some wrote words such as solace for solar,. For **spines**, they wrote spans, spins which have different meanings in English. For **wings**, some wrote window and ring.

Exercise 2

The exercise was accessible to a majority of the candidates.

Purpose:

- **Protect**

Comment

Most candidates were able to score a mark in this question. However, a few were unable to score due to spelling errors and new words. For example for protect some wrote protective and protector,

Writing process:

- **dedication**
- **Incredible**

The items were accessible to a majority of candidates. A few were unable to score due to spelling errors.

For dedication, some wrote 'delication' for instance.

Expectations:

- **optimistic**

Comment

This item was most accessible to candidates though some could not score due to spelling mistakes, coming up with new words like, optimum and estimatic which either did not make sense or had different meanings to what was communicated.

Future aspirations:

- **endangered**

Comment

This item was accessible to a majority of candidates. Nonetheless, some were unable to score due to spelling mistakes and coming up with new words e.g. danger, endanger, bio diversity.

Exercise 3

In this exercise candidates were required to listen to an interview about lions with a Game Ranger, Don and then fill in details. This exercise was accessible as most candidates obtained maximum marks. However, a few could not score due to wrong spellings, creating meaningless words or those that achieved different shades of meaning.

Symbolism:

Expected response:

- **courage**
- **strength**

Comment

This item was accessible except those who were let down by spelling. For courage candidates gave responses such as current, encourages, character, brave etc. On the same item, for strength, they gave incorrect spelling such as: shtrength.

Mane

Expected response: throat

Comment

This item was quite inaccessible for a sizeable number of candidates as they failed to contextualise. Instead of writing 'throat' most candidates came up with; fload, slot, thrown, throne, trout, through, forest, fraud etc.

Routine

Expected response:

- prey, vision
- 7kg, 40kg

Comment

This item was quite accessible to a number of candidates. However, a few were let down by the spelling of 'prey' and 'vision.' They came up with responses such as pray, preyers, prayers, preay and pry instead of 'prey'. On the same item for 7kg some candidates came up with 70kg, 750kg and for 40kg.

Fearsome

Expected response:

- Predators

Comment

This item was a bit challenging to most candidates. They were let down mostly by spelling. They came up with: predictions, predates, predictions while some missed it completely and came up with responses such as: animals, rhinos, etc.

Nemesis

Expected response:

- Hyenas

- Poachers

Comment

This item was fairly accessible to most candidates. However, a few were failed by spelling, of both responses. They came up with hyena, hayena (SiSwati), heines, etc. and for poachers, most candidates wrote prochers, pschers, approaches etc.

Exercise 4

This exercise required candidates to listen to a talk about taking a break from technology and playing board games and then answer the questions. The exercise was quite inaccessible as most candidates scored below average.

Question 1

What does the *Unplug Yourself* drive encourage people to do?

Expected Response:

- to remove yourself from all things tech
- spend time with family and friends over games (any one)
- have fun by playing games

Comment

This question was fairly accessible to the majority of the candidates. The only challenge was that some candidates omitted some key words to the answer. For instance, in the response “spend time with family and friends leaving over games” most candidates left out over games which was key. This was the most popular response that the candidates attempted.

Question 2

How does playing board games enhance brain function? Give two details.

Expected Response:

- (playing) stimulates the brain in different ways
- (practise) essential cognitive skills

Comment

This question was relatively accessible to most candidates. However, they were only able to score at most only a mark instead of two. The most popular response was: “stimulates the brain in different ways”. Most

candidates also provided incomplete responses by omitting key words. They wrote responses like “stimulates the brain”. Other candidates had spelling errors hence they could not score a mark. Notably, with the second response candidates also left out details like “essential cognitive skills”.

Question 3

What might games offer children?

Expected response:

- (some) distraction and entertainment/fun

Comment

This question proved to be inaccessible to a majority of candidates as they gave completely irrelevant responses. Other candidates gave partial responses, for instance, “entertainment”, “distraction” yet both details were required to score the mark.

Question 4

Why is laughter a necessary ingredient when playing games?

Expected response:

- for an enjoyable learning experience

This question also proved to be inaccessible as candidates gave partial responses omitting “experience” or spelt it wrongly.

Question 5

How does playing games improve one’s personality?

Expected response:

- offers space or opportunity to open up/show creative side of the individual’s personality.
- leads to a greater self-esteem.

Comment

Most candidates omitted the action words which were key to score a mark. Also, the candidates left out the keywords such as “offers/creates” which rendered their responses irrelevant.

Exercise 5

Candidates were expected to listen to a presentation about the International Space Station (ISS) and then answered the questions that followed. This exercise proved to be the most challenging as the majority of candidates were unable to get the required marks.

Question 1

Where exactly will the International Space Station (ISS) be retired?

Expected Response:

- in the middle of the Pacific Ocean

Comment

This question was fairly accessible to most candidates. However, some candidates failed to score because they were omitting part of the response. For example, they provided responses such as 'Pacific Ocean' omitting 'middle of' or 'Ocean' only – omitting. Also, notable is that there were responses with 'sea' instead of 'Ocean' resulting in candidates failing to score. Some candidates failed to identify the correct answer and gave NASA instead of the expected response.

Question 2

What would happen if the ISS was hit by a piece of junk?

Expected Response:

- create a shower of debris/threaten all satellites orbiting the Earth

Comment

This question was inaccessible since quite a number of candidates could not score a mark. Most candidates gave incorrect information such as 'it will create a shower of degree'/'it will create a shallow of degree'. Notable were the incorrect spellings of the word 'debris', 'satellite' and 'orbiting'. Some candidates could not score due to mixing a part of option 1 with a part of option 2, for example 'create a shower of that threatens satellites orbiting the Earth'.

Question 3

What threat might be brought about by the dropping of the station?

Expected Responses:

- (It can) destroy/destruction of marine life/a threat to/harm marine conservation

Comment

This question was inaccessible to a majority of candidates because a number of them were not able to score a mark. They failed to score a mark due to giving incorrect responses such as 'causes danger to humans instead of marine life'; 'marine will be killed. Some candidates gave a comparative type of response, for example, 'they cause a danger to humans than to marine life' or 'they cause little danger to humans as compared to marine life'. Most notable were incorrect spellings of marine and leaving blank spaces.

Question 4

What prompted the plan to vacate and de-orbit the ISS? Give two details.

Expected Response:

- In-flight systems past their expiry/expiring date
- cracks in one (Zarya) of the modules
- air leaks in crew's living quarters (any two)

Comment

Most candidates were unable to score all the marks; only partial success was noted in a few responses. Candidates gave incorrect responses such as; 'have started to appear'/'air leaks in the quarters'/'systems' instead of 'in-flight systems'. There were instances of incorrect spellings of key words, for example, 'cruise' instead of 'crew's'; 'licks' instead of 'leaks'; and 'passed' instead of 'past'.

Question 5

State two prospects for NASA.

Expected response

- Commercial/paid visit/ people able to pay to stay on the station
- Future space exploration/ (plan) to build a similar station/Gateway

Comment

This question was fairly accessible since a majority of the candidates managed to score at least one mark. Those who could not score gave incorrect responses such as 'single', 'serious', instead of 'similar'. Some candidates gave incomplete responses due to omitting key words such as 'to stay'/'to pay' in 'people able to

pay to stay on the station' as well as omitting 'similar' in 'to build a similar station'. In addition, some could not score due to flouting rules for writing proper nouns in the word 'Gateway'. Other candidates gave a hyphenated form of 'Gateway' i.e. 'Gate-way'. Also notable were incorrect use of prepositions such as 'with'/'by'/'through' the station.

Conclusion

The listening comprehension exam effectively differentiated between candidates with strong auditory processing skills and those struggling with inference, technical vocabulary and structured responses. Performance was strongest in everyday scenarios and weakest in specialised scientific contexts.

Recommendations

- Extensive reading is key as most candidates could hear the answers but failed to write the responses correctly due to lack of language skills.
- Learners should be taught inferential skills.
- Teachers should teach the listening skill and help candidates to practice it.
- The principles of grammar should be taught.
- Teachers should encourage learners to use clear and legible handwriting.
- Learners should avoid too much cancelling/overwriting.
- Teachers should encourage learners to listen to the introduction of each exercise so that they can be familiar with the context.
- Teachers are encouraged to familiarise the learners with 'top-down' and 'bottom-up' processing strategies when it comes to listening. Top-down processing uses background knowledge and contextualises words to aid comprehension while bottom-up processing has to do with sounds, words and other small units to create meaning.
- Teachers should teach their learners spelling conventions.
- Teachers should teach learners vocabulary and also familiarise them with different accents.
- Teachers should teach learners question analysis and phrasing answers properly to avoid giving responses that are incomplete.

PAPER 6873/04
Oral Communication

This is a paper that is school based - that is to say, it is tested and graded by teachers at school level.

General Comments

The performance of candidates in the 2025 examination on this component displayed great improvement as compared to the previous year. There were a lot of candidates who scored above average and only a few scored below average. A majority of the candidates were able to relate to the different issues discussed. However, there were some instances where examiners failed to probe candidates, which disadvantaged them as they could not elaborate to make it a lively discussion. Such candidates could not score good marks as they could not express themselves extensively. Most notably, some examiners limited candidates who were leading conversations by rigidly focusing only on the given bullet points. Some examiners intimidated the candidates by making the conversations more like an interview. In some instances, candidates went on unguided in conversations.

It should be noted that even though this exam does not test content, candidates are able to elaborate on topics they relate to freely. They fail to elaborate on topics they are not comfortable with – similarly, the examiners' guidance plays a very important role. This therefore becomes an important factor in their performance.

Three out of the five cards (**Card A – Relations**, **Card B – Food**, **Card E – Helping others**) were popular and were done fairly well. Card C – **Owning a Home** and Card D – **Missed Opportunities** were least popular among the cards.

Question Analysis

Card A – Relations

This card was accessible for a majority of candidates who got it. It proved to be particularly friendly and non-discriminating as it accommodated candidates from all walks of life. This is because every candidate could easily relate to the topic as relations begin from family level. Another reason why candidates related very easily is that it afforded them a chance to narrate their experiences. Candidates described and narrated at length the relationships they have with their parents, siblings, friends, colleagues, neighbours, countries, etc. They gave reasons for their choice of favourite relationships. Most candidates spoke fondly about the relationships they have with their parents. Some even went to an extent of speaking about love relationships.

Good candidates managed to mention and explain elaborately the importance of good relationships. For example, they said it is for progress sake, especially in a student-to-student relationship. They were able to state consequences of ruined relationships. Some of the consequences they mentioned include the fact that broken relationships create toxic environments, can lead to depression, create enmity, can even escalate murder cases, etc.

To further display how this card favoured many candidates is displayed by the way they explained how elders could ensure good relations amongst family members. Many candidates emphasised the importance of resolving conflicts among family members. Some even mentioned that elders are not supposed to display any favouritism among family members. Some even went to the extent of emphasizing the importance of cementing family bonds through family gatherings, etc. .

On the aspect of how countries can maintain good relations with other countries, candidates mentioned the point about strengthening trade amongst countries and creating Diplomatic relations with other countries. Some candidates even mentioned the importance of social events such as soccer tournaments and cultural exchange events to help create good relations amongst countries.

The overall performance of candidates who were given this card was exceptionally good, more especially to candidates who are proficient in the English language. It favoured even average students because the issue of relations is something they also have experience of.

Card B – Food

This is another card which proved more accessible to candidates because food is a basic need to human beings and all candidates displayed having knowledge about food. Those candidates who were given this card provided clear definition of food. From the onset, candidates were able to identify their favourite and least liked foods although most of them not being able to give clear reasons why. Good candidates were able to

have specific register to mention and describe different dishes – both traditional and western. Those from rural areas delved much into traditional food which they are exposed to. Some of them could not tell the difference between least liked food and the food they have overeaten e.g. Porridge and Beans.

On the aspect of having enough food, families were advised by candidates to do subsistence farming in order to ensure there is enough food for their members. Candidates also suggested budgeting, asking for donations, provision of job opportunities, proper food storage, the list is endless. Consequences of food shortage were cited by candidates as malnutrition, increased hospitalization, high death rate, stress, anxiety, prostitution, lack of concentration in class, high failure rate, social isolation, stigma, etc.

Candidates pleaded with their government to provide job opportunities for citizens so that they can put food on the table. Increasing salaries was another strategy mentioned as well as supporting local farmers by giving them resources at a subsidised fee, insurance to small-scale farmers, building of orphanages, donating food parcels, etc.

At face value, it looked like an easy card, yet on deliberation, it required a lot of explanations which some candidates failed to give, especially on the last two bullets.

Card C – Owning a Home

This was a less popular card since the idea of owning a home is beyond their league although they do dream of owning a home. Candidates who were able to access this card gave clear descriptions of their favourite homes and reasons for their choices and a majority were able to use precise vocabulary such as *mansion*, *cottage*, *apartment*, *double-storey*, *modern plan*, *gabled-roof*, *balcony* and words like *ensuite bathroom*, *open plan design*, *spacious*. Weak candidates were those who lacked appropriate vocabulary to describe their dream homes and used words such as *nice*, *big* etc, and failed to state the location of choice and why it is suitable for them. They also used words such as *kukhonta*, *bandlancane*, *libandla* when describing what one can do to own a home.

Moreover, candidates had difficulty in stating what government can do to encourage people to own homes. Most examiners were able to ask relevant questions on the topic, which helped the candidates to be able to express themselves. However, there were rare cases where examiners probed the candidates using only the bullet points without rephrasing or simplifying.

Card D – Missed Opportunities

This was the least popular card. Candidates who performed well were those who understood what a missed opportunity is or had truly once missed that opportunity. Good responses mentioned opportunities they once

missed, which had a major impact on their lives. These included opportunities such as travelling abroad, school trips, getting a scholarship or meeting someone dear in their lives for the first time and such candidates were able to attach their feelings.

However, this card proved to be inaccessible to some candidates as they stated minor things such as missing a bus or missing out in a game. Such candidates failed to understand that missing an opportunity required them to talk about something that would have a major impact on their lives. They also failed to give reasons why people miss out on opportunities and how countries can ensure not to miss out on opportunities. Only a few candidates were able to outline the role of government in ensuring that opportunities are not missed.

Card E- Helping others

This was one of the popular cards as candidates were able to express themselves freely on life experiences like helping at home, school and at community level. This included volunteering, sharing resources, or even emotional support. They associated helping others with social responsibility and empathy. They were able to give examples of charity organizations such as: World Vision, Bantwana, Young Heroes and many more. They related in that they had received help at some point in their lives.

Candidates who did not perform well only gave overly idealistic answers without real examples. Some mentioned rewards such as blessings without giving full explanation. Furthermore, some candidates had limited vocabulary to describe actions and impact of help, while others believed that helping others only means giving money. Candidates confused helping others with performing duties at home. Most interestingly, they made it sound like they are doing their parents a favour when they work at home.

It was clear that they mostly lamented on the fact that at most times, this creates a dependency syndrome and enmity when one stops offering help to someone.

Points of concern regarding examiners

- In some instances, examiners failed to lead or prompt candidates towards the right direction.
- Some examiners had challenges in following the marking criteria. They were either too lenient or too severe when awarding marks. Examiners should always refer closely to the marking criteria for each and every candidate for proper allocation of marks.
- where there are two or more examiners in the Centre, there was display of lack of co-ordination. Examiners should first coordinate their understanding of the marking criteria beforehand to reach a common ground and do internal moderation after administering the exam to minimise mark variation.

- Also worth noting was that the examiners had a tendency of ‘cornering’ candidates by asking them tricky questions, channeling them to their (examiners’) own school of thought.
- Some examiners’ line of questioning demanded candidates to either agree or disagree hence making it difficult for candidates to express their own viewpoints which were not those of the teacher-examiner.

Conducting the oral exam

A few challenges were noted from the way the exam was conducted. These are detailed below.

Part A – Welcome and brief explanation

This is where the examiner is expected to begin the recording by giving the candidate’s name and number, date and examiner’s name. Some examiners failed to do this, while others were inconsistent in that they did not explain procedure to candidates.

Some examiners gave a wrong examination number or a wrong name to a particular candidate. Sometimes they labelled candidates’ names wrongly in the tracks. Examiners are urged to always use the Attendance Register to verify candidates’ names and numbers, mark present and absent candidates.

A number of examiners also failed to use this part to briefly explain what was going to happen in the course of the exam. In some centres where there were two or more examiners, the examination was not well coordinated. You would find that one examiner would follow the procedure correctly while the others did not. Examiners are advised to coordinate their understanding of the Examiner’s Notes before conducting the examination so that a common standard is applied to all candidates.

Part B – Warm up

This is the session where a candidate is put at ease by talking about himself/ herself, on anything worth talking about. The observation was that it was a challenge for some examiners. Some sessions were conspicuously long while others were shorter than the stipulated 2-3 minutes. Some examiners mentioned all the cards or rather the contents of each card in this section, which is discouraged. Examiners are advised to discuss general issues that will put candidates at ease and help them get used to the examination situation. After that the examiner should then decide which card will be given to the candidate. It is worth noting that most examiners were able to use the warm-up effectively. However, some examiners discussed the contents of the assessment cards during the warm up session which is greatly discouraged.

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- Some examiners did not use the warm-up sessions to help candidates get used to the examination situation. Examiners are encouraged to ask the candidate general questions about himself/herself, school, hobbies, career, etc and avoid thematic questions. Some warm up sessions were rather too long, resulting to the main part of the exam being short.
- Mentioning candidate's number and name, examiner's name and date was not consistent in some centres.
- In some centres, explanation of the exam procedure was not applied in the same way to all the candidates - Examiners are reminded to consult the Examiner's/Teacher's Notes to ensure they conform to the expectations of conducting the exam. It is expected that a common standard procedure is applied to all the candidates.

Part C – Handing the card to candidate

Handing the Assessment Card to the candidate was satisfactorily done by some examiners. At this point, the examiner should mention which card has been selected for the candidate. This process should always be on record, and the examiner must pause the recording. This should be indicated by saying 'the recording will now be paused'. This allows the external moderator to know that the candidate was given time to study the card.

It was quite disturbing that some examiners assigned the assessment card even before they started the Warm-up.

Part D- Conversation

This is the main part of the test which is assessed. It showed great improvement. However, some examiners failed to adhere to the stipulated time, which is about 6-9 minutes. Some conversations were conspicuously long or rather too short. Examiners are reminded to expertly control candidates so that they do not stretch the conversations for too long. Short conversations were partly because the examiners did not clarify the prompts for the candidates, simplify or unpack where needed. Those particular candidates had difficulty expressing themselves.

In some instances, examiners simply read the prompts as they were on the card then asked the candidates what they thought about them. When the candidates were confronted with such, they had difficulty in expressing their views without the examiner's guidance. Others were forced to make long presentations without the examiner's assistance. This is strongly discouraged as the test is supposed to be a conversation between the candidate and the examiner, not a presentation.

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In some few instances, examiners gave candidates very little time to express themselves, but the examiner took most of the time giving his/her own views. Such. Examiners are strongly advised to avoid this as it deprives candidates of the chance to elaborate freely. Examiners should always remember that they are there to guide each candidate through the conversation and should always appear interested in what the candidate is saying. The expectation is that the examiner should then allocate marks accordingly.

Some examiners did not arrange the recordings on the USBs numerically as they appeared on the attendance register. The summary form should also follow that order. A few centres submitted USBs with incomplete recordings, with missing candidates or recordings with no sound. In some instances, USBs were empty, with no recordings at all. Having said that, **examiners are urged to listen to the recordings and create a back-up before submitting them to ECESWA.**

Overall, the use of USBs provided by ECESWA limited the problems greatly in this exam.

Paperwork

This year a few mistakes were encountered and they included the following:

- Using pencil when filling in the Summary Form then overwrite with a pen – always use ink;
- Wrong calculation of marks on the Summary Forms – it is advisable to cross-check if the calculations have been done correctly;
- Transferring wrong marks from Summary Sheet to MS1;
- Converting marks to percentage;
- Some candidates had no marks in the Summary Forms yet they appeared in the recording and also on the MS1. The distribution of marks on the Summary Forms is very important for moderation purposes. In case of internal moderation, examiners are advised to provide the distribution too;
- Absent candidates were not marked appropriately in the Attendance Registers and MS1 Form – always make sure that absent candidates are marked appropriately, do not leave blank spaces;
- Always submit the Attendance Register and the duplicate should remain at the Centre as a form of back-up copy. Centres are reminded to always submit all relevant material to ECESWA: **marked Attendance Register, completed Summary Form, all recorded USBs with labels and MS1 Form.**
- The MS1 Form must have numerical scores transferred correctly from the Summary Form (do not convert into percentage) and it should be shaded appropriately and neatly.

NB: If there is a candidate with special needs (who cannot partake in this exam), the centre should formally apply to ECESWA for an exemption early, and not casually mention it during exam time.

Recorded USBs

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Generally, recordings have greatly improved. However, there were still a few centres where problems were encountered. These included the following:

- Some recordings were inaudible (volume too low especially the candidate's part) – centres are urged to check their USBs for audibility before submission and also ensure that every candidate is clearly audible. Examiners are urged to ensure that recording device is closer to the candidate than themselves.
- Other centres submitted empty USBs – Examiners should always check their recordings before submission.
- Some centres did not submit all the candidates' recordings while for other centres some conversations did not run up to the end – centres must ensure that all candidates appear on the recording before submitting to ECESWA.
- In some centres, there was a lot of background noise, either from the recording equipment or external noise. It is important to check audibility levels throughout the oral testing session to ensure that voices are clearly audible.
- For a few centres, the recording was just one long file for all the candidates, instead of separate files for each candidate, labelled with his/her examination number and name. This helps to see that all candidates are present in the recording.
- Examiners/teachers are also encouraged to label candidates (candidate number and name) in the recordings for easy identification.
- Examiners are advised to arrange candidates in the USBs in the order in which they appear in the Attendance Register.

Conversations

Once the Oral Exam has begun the recording should run without interruption, with the exception of a permitted pause between the warm-up and the main part of the exam. There was great improvement in this section, except for only a few instances as compared to the previous years. These included some of the following:

- Some examiners conducted the oral exam as if it was a 'question and answer' session, or a presentation – this is supposed to be a conversation.
- Some examiners dominated the conversations and even enforced their views on candidates. Examiners are reminded that the purpose of the oral session is to examine candidates, and as such, they should be given more time to talk than the examiners themselves.

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- Examiners are encouraged to ask 'open' questions which allow candidates to respond at length and that they should not interrupt with their own views.
- Some examiners/teachers did not simplify the prompts for the candidates, sometimes resulting in weak candidates being stuck and not knowing how to proceed with the examination. It is important to simplify the prompts to the candidates so that even the weak candidates can be able to say something on the issue being discussed. It is also equally important to unpack and simplify the stem of the question to ensure that each candidate understands what it means. If it becomes apparent that the candidate finds the topic difficult or inappropriate, it is permissible to move into more productive areas, rather than to stick rigidly to the examiner's prompts.
- Examiners are encouraged to read and follow the guide stipulated in the Teacher's/Examiner's Notes.
- To conduct oral tests effectively, good examiners should familiarise themselves with the oral test before the test is conducted.

Conclusion

Examiners are applauded for the splendid work done in the 2025 English Language Oral Examination. Nevertheless, examiners are encouraged to continue with the spirit of working as a team in their departments whilst preparing the candidates and conducting the exam together. Centres must ensure that their recording equipment is in good condition and also check audibility levels before recording begins. Moreover, centres that have two or more examiners are advised to conduct internal workshops beforehand so that a common working criterion is applied by all examiners when awarding marks. Most importantly, the department is encouraged to do internal moderation in order to allocate marks appropriately.

Finally, examiners are encouraged to seek advice or consult ECESWA every time they face internal problems or need clarity when conducting the Oral Exam before submitting relevant material to ECESWA.

